inferred, was to induct officers who knew the Tamil language, at a time when Tamil Nadu Police was seen divided between various political camps. New Delhi did not feel comfortable picking one of them to head the SIT.

The structure of this SIT was going to be different from those in the past. The SIT headed by Anand Ram, which had probed the assassination of Indira Gandhi, reported to the cabinet secretary and the home minister. But the SIT under Kaarthikeyan would be functioning as an independent unit within the CBI and Kaarthikeyan would report to Director Vijay Karan and his deputy S.K. Datta.

Kaarthikeyan took up the challenging task, laying down a few conditions that were all accepted by the bosses. But within hours he understood it was going to be a much bigger challenge than he had initially thought. Many fellow officers told him there was still time to get out of this one as it was a ‘blind case’ and that he would never succeed. His batchmates from the IPS told him that the political pressure on this case would be humongous. Kaarthikeyan told Anirudhya later that, after all this, he felt even more motivated to crack the case.

The formation of the SIT’s core group was already being discussed at the CBI’s Lodi Road headquarters. Bobb wanted a quick profile of them to go in the next *India Today* cover story. Getting the details, therefore, was crucial for Anirudhya. Names started pouring in, starting with Radhavinod Raju and Amod Kanth. Anirudhya dialled Verma’s Delhi residence and asked Shobhana for a number where he could reach him. She laughed and said she didn’t know any other than his direct line. Next Anirudhya dialled Kanth’s home number and got an almost identical reply from his wife, Rekha Kanth. He got the message. He need not call them again.

Raju was a 1975-batch Jammu and Kashmir cadre. He had handled sensitive terrorist cases and knew how to read a militant’s mind. He had cracked cases of financial scams in Kerala and a few murder cases too. His speciality was counter-insurgency, which is why he had spent so much time in J&K. Kanth, too, was high-profile because of his sensitive handling of the anti-Sikh riots in 1984 Delhi. He had handled investigations into two assassination cases—Indira Gandhi’s and Lalit Maken’s. He had been